

How Parliaments Polarize: Legislative Replacement and Adaptation in Chile

Under review

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Abstract

Political polarization is widely documented, yet we know less about how elite polarization accumulates inside representative institutions over time, and whether long-run increases reflect replacement (the entry of more extreme legislators) or adaptation (within-legislator positional change). Using roll-call votes from the Chilean Chamber of Deputies across six legislative periods (2002-2026) and dynamically anchored ideal-point estimates on a common scale, this article traces secular changes in revealed ideology and decomposes rising extremity into compositional turnover versus within-legislator movement. Polarization, measured as average absolute distance from a fixed reference point, increased by approximately 76% between legislative periods 2002-06 and 2022-26, with no evidence of sharp discontinuities around relevant political events. New entrants are, on average, more extreme than incumbents, while the within-legislator specification shows no systematic increase in extremity after entry. A replacement-only counterfactual that holds legislators fixed at their entry extremity reproduces essentially the entire observed increase, indicating that long-run polarization is descriptively accounted for by cumulative compositional replacement rather than systematic within-legislator adaptation.

Introduction

Elite ideological polarization has been extensively documented in party systems and legislatures (Dalton 2008; Hix, Noury, and Roland 2006). A related literature documents partisan hostility (Iyengar et al. 2019; Reiljan 2020; Wagner 2024), which can hinder cooperation and deliberation (Binder 1999; Bächtiger 2004; McCarty, Poole, and Rosenthal 2006). Yet we know considerably less about how polarization accumulates within parliaments over time. An

increasingly polarized chamber may result from changes in who gains legislative office, from changes in the behavior of legislators already serving, or from both processes. Distinguishing between these possibilities is central to understanding how parliamentary composition and legislative careers jointly shape long-run ideological change. This raises the question of this article: does polarization mainly reflect the entry of more extreme cohorts (replacement), or do legislators themselves become progressively more extreme after entering office (adaptation)?

The point is that aggregate trends can look similar under very different micro-level processes. Existing research has been far more successful at documenting that polarization exists than at specifying how it accumulates over time. Many studies track changes in aggregate levels without isolating whether shifts stem from compositional turnover or from systematic movement within individual legislative careers. Polarization is therefore often treated as an aggregate outcome to be measured, but replacement and adaptation have different implications for how polarization accumulates across successive legislatures.

The challenge becomes especially relevant in contexts of declining party attachment, high electoral volatility, and weakened channels of representation. Such conditions can simultaneously reshape electoral recruitment and alter the incentives legislators face once elected. They therefore provide a particularly useful setting in which to examine whether long-run parliamentary polarization is associated primarily with changes in membership or with behavioral change during legislative careers.

This article addresses these issues by examining the evolution of ideological polarization in the Chilean Chamber of Deputies across six legislative periods, from 2002 to 2026, using roll-call vote data and dynamic ideal-point estimation. Chile is analytically valuable because this period combines gradual institutional change—most notably the end of the governing coalition that ruled the country since 1990 and a series of substantive political reforms—with mounting challenges to political representation, including the 2019 social unrest and the pandemic period. This combination allows polarization to be examined both as a cumulative process unfolding within a relatively stable institutional framework and as the product of discrete shocks or abrupt realignments. Over this period, our primary measure of legislative polarization increases by approximately 76%, providing a substantively large long-run change for distinguishing between replacement and adaptation.

The empirical strategy distinguishes these processes by combining cross-cohort and within-legislator evidence. A replacement account implies that successive cohorts of entrants should appear at systematically greater levels of extremity while legislators exhibit limited movement after entry. An adaptation account instead implies increasing extremity within legislative careers. The analysis evaluates both patterns and complements them with a replacement-only accounting counterfactual that holds legislators at their entry extremity while allowing chamber composition to change.

The article makes two principal contributions. First, it provides longitudinal evidence on parliamentary polarization using dynamically comparable roll-call ideal points across six complete legislative terms. Second, it shows that a substantial secular increase in chamber-level

polarization can arise through cumulative compositional replacement even in the absence of systematic movement toward greater extremity within legislative careers. This distinction shifts attention from aggregate polarization trends to the micro-level processes through which they accumulate over time.

Ideological Polarization and the Dynamics of Parliamentary Change

Roll-call votes are rule-governed decisions that can be scaled into a latent ideological structure that allows researchers to trace changes in elite positioning over time using observed voting behavior (Poole and Rosenthal 1997; Clinton, Jackman, and Rivers 2004). Recent comparative parliamentary research has likewise used legislative voting to examine polarization across multiparty settings (Christiansen 2021), including the Chilean context (Campos-Parra and Navia 2025). Accordingly, the analysis relies on roll-call voting rather than on rhetoric, surveys, or self-placement measures, which are more commonly used to study affective polarization - a distinct but parallel dimension of polarization centered on attitudes, identities, and intergroup affect (Iyengar et al. 2019).

Aggregate increases in roll-call-based polarization can be observationally equivalent to very different underlying processes. Measured divergence may rise because more extreme legislators enter office and gradually replace earlier cohorts. Also, it may rise because incumbents update their revealed positioning as institutional and electoral incentives shift. Recent work shows that apparent changes in legislative ideal points may even partly reflect changes in the votes being cast and the issues reaching the floor, making it important to distinguish shifts in chamber composition from changes in legislators' own trajectories (Moskowitz, Rogowski, and Snyder 2024). Distinguishing these processes is therefore necessary before assigning a substantive explanation to an aggregate increase in polarization.

Within this identification problem, the literature draws a useful distinction between compositional and within-actor sources of polarization. Compositional accounts emphasize replacement: polarization increases because the ideological profile of those entering office differs systematically from that of those already serving, so aggregate divergence can rise even if incumbents themselves remain relatively stable (Theriault 2006; Bonica 2014; Thomsen 2014). Replacement should therefore be understood as a cumulative parliamentary process rather than only as a contemporaneous difference between newcomers and incumbents. Legislators who enter at relatively extreme positions may remain in office across subsequent terms and become part of the incumbent parliamentary stock. If successive cohorts enter at increasingly extreme positions, polarization can accumulate across legislatures even when individual members exhibit little or no ideological movement after entry. Within-actor accounts, by contrast, emphasize adaptation: polarization increases because legislators already in office become more extreme over time relative to the political environment in which they operate. Such movement may reflect changing electoral incentives, nomination pressures, coordination structures, or other features of institutional competition (Weingast and Marshall 1988; Cox and McCubbins 2005; Cowburn and Theriault 2025). More broadly, electoral and nomination rules can affect

both who enters office and the incentives legislators face once elected, with documented consequences for legislative behavior (Alvarez and Sinclair 2012). These mechanisms imply different diagnoses, even when their aggregate consequences look deceptively similar.

The empirical challenge is therefore to determine whether rising polarization is primarily compositional or whether it also accumulates within legislative careers. A replacement account predicts that newcomers should enter at systematically more extreme positions than incumbents, while incumbents should show limited systematic movement toward greater extremity after entry (Theriault 2006; Bonica 2014). An adaptation account predicts the opposite micro-level pattern: even after conditioning on entry position, legislators who remain in office should become progressively more extreme over time. Distinguishing these predictions requires comparing legislators not only across cohorts, but also against their own initial positions, while remaining attentive to the possibility that changing vote content may generate observationally similar aggregate trends (Moskowitz, Rogowski, and Snyder 2024).

The Chilean Chamber 2002-2026 provides unusual empirical leverage to test these predictions because it combines repeated observations of individual legislators with substantial changes in chamber composition over an extended period. This structure permits the analysis to compare successive entry cohorts while also tracking changes within legislative careers. Within this period, studies document declining party identification and strains in political representation (Luna and Altman 2011; Bargsted and Maldonado 2018), alongside a weakening of the post-transition consensus and increasing political elite polarization associated with changing electoral competition (Fábrega, González, and Lindh 2018; Lindh, Fábrega, and González 2019). Luna (2024) characterizes this configuration as “disjointed polarization,” in which political conflict intensifies within institutions despite weak and volatile citizen alignments. Evidence from legislative institutions also points to meaningful heterogeneity in elite behavior: representatives respond to electoral vulnerability, intraparty position, and constituency characteristics (Dockendorff 2020), while independents in Chile’s 2021–22 Constitutional Convention exhibited greater roll-call polarization than party members (Campos-Parra and Navia 2025). The 2002-2026 window is also substantively useful because it starts when *La Concertación*, the governing coalition that had dominated Chilean politics since the democratic transition, was still in office, and extends through 2026, after its dissolution and the emergence of new coalitions and parties. Thus, the resulting twenty-four-year window encompasses substantial transformations in Chilean electoral competition and party-system structure.

Method and Data

On the measurement of dynamic polarization

The analysis uses the publicly available roll-call voting database collected by Fábrega (2025) for the Chilean Chamber of Deputies, covering six legislative terms between 2002 and 2026.

The focus is on the Chamber of Deputies rather than the Senate for three reasons. First, deputies are elected in smaller territorial districts, yielding more granular territorial representation than senatorial constituencies (Servicio Electoral de Chile n.d.). Second, the Chamber frequently serves as the chamber of origin, shaping bills in the first constitutional procedure before review by the revising chamber and, when needed, mixed-commission bargaining to resolve inter-chamber disagreements (OECD 2012). Third, it is typically the initial national legislative post in Chilean political careers, making it a natural setting to study both entry and early behavioral adaptation (Saldaña 2014; Morgenstern and Siavelis 2008). For these reasons, roll-call voting in the lower chamber offers a particularly informative window into legislators’ revealed positioning early in the lawmaking sequence, before the additional revision and negotiation steps that can arise later in the bicameral process (Poole and Rosenthal 1997; OECD 2012).

A recurring concern in periodized analyses of roll-call behavior is that changes in agenda processing could mechanically affect measured dispersion. Table 1 partially addresses this issue by summarizing roll-call activity by legislative period, including the total number of unique bills and roll-calls, as well as the distribution of votes by bill origin and legislative stage as officially classified. Two patterns stand out. First, both the number of bills and the number of roll-calls increase over the observation window. Second, this sustained growth in activity is not accompanied by monotonic or systematic shifts in the composition of votes across bill origins or stages of the lawmaking process. Whether bills originate in presidential messages or parliamentary motions, and whether votes occur in first, second, or later legislative stages, the observed shares fluctuate across periods without a clear directional trend.

These patterns point to broad procedural continuity in parliamentary activity over time. This continuity holds despite substantial changes in chamber composition, most notably the expansion from 120 to 155 deputies following the 2015 electoral reform (Law No. 20,840), which first took effect in the 2018–2022 legislative period. The same term also encompassed the 2019 social unrest and the COVID-19 pandemic, developments that plausibly affected elite incentives and the substantive agenda of parliamentary conflict. The absence of a corresponding monotonic change in bill origin or legislative stage therefore provides some reassurance that the longitudinal polarization pattern is not mechanically associated with these observable procedural dimensions.

Table 1: Roll-call composition by period: totals (votes and bills) and percentage shares by bill origin and legislative stage.

descriptor	2002-06	2006-10	2010-14	2014-18	2018-22	2022-26
Total roll-calls (N)	1950.0	1990.0	3082.0	3267.0	3520.0	4126.0
Total bills (unique N)	479.0	552.0	558.0	573.0	703.0	675.0
Origin: presidential message (%)	74.2	76.3	82.4	79.7	65.1	72.6
Origin: parliamentary motion (%)	25.8	23.7	17.6	20.3	34.9	27.4
Stage: mixed committee (%)	3.4	2.2	1.9	1.7	2.6	1.6

Stage: presidential observations (%)	0.7	2.0	1.3	0.3	2.6	0.5
Stage: first reading (%)	66.1	72.2	65.5	68.2	68.9	68.2
Stage: second reading (%)	9.2	7.6	15.5	10.3	12.1	11.8
Stage: third reading (%)	20.5	15.7	15.2	19.1	13.8	17.4
Stage: single reading (%)	0.0	0.3	0.6	0.4	0.1	0.5

Source: Author’s elaboration based on Fábrega (2025).

Another concern is dimensionality. In this regard, we run two-dimensional DW-NOMINATE diagnostics on each period’s complete roll-call dataset and find a strongly dominant first dimension in every legislature (mean $\lambda_1/\lambda_2 = 20.2$, with 95.1 percent of the two-dimensional dispersion captured by the first dimension), supporting the use of a unidimensional dynamic scale. See Supplemental Materials 1 (SM1, note: supplemental materials available at https://github.com/jfabregalacoa/polarization_ssrn). This finding is consistent with a large comparative literature showing that legislative voting is primarily structured by a dominant ideological dimension (Poole and Rosenthal 1997), including in multiparty systems (Hix, Noury, and Roland 2006). Prior studies of the Chilean Congress similarly confirm that a unidimensional structure captures most systematic variation in roll-call voting (Alemán and Saiegh 2007). At the same time, recent work on mass politics in Chile documents the emergence of a second, anti-establishment dimension in the post-2019 period, based on survey evidence of citizens’ attitudes and political alignments (Argote and Visconti 2025; Argote, de la Cerda, and Visconti 2025). We take this literature seriously, but it speaks to a different level of analysis. Our diagnostic concerns the structure of roll-call voting within the legislature itself, where a single dominant dimension continues to organize revealed behavior throughout the period under study.

Once dimensionality has been solved, we estimate ideological positions dynamically across periods rather than independently for each legislature. Legislators’ voting probabilities are modeled as a function of a latent continuous position along a principal ideological dimension, conventionally interpreted as the left–right axis. The analysis adopts a dynamic ideal-point estimation strategy with longitudinal anchoring, following Lo, Imai, and Olmsted (2022). This approach enables joint estimation across periods on a common scale, providing a stable reference for assessing changes in ideological dispersion over time while remaining computationally feasible for large roll-call datasets.

In line with standard practice, abstentions and absences are treated as missing information, while near-unanimous votes contribute little to identification by construction. As a result, the estimates are not sensitive to additional filtering of low-discrimination items or to alternative weighting schemes based on item discrimination (e.g., Poole and Rosenthal 1997; Clinton, Jackman, and Rivers 2004). Additional robustness checks address selective participation. We re-estimate ideal points after excluding legislators whose absences meet or exceed alternative thresholds. In that regard, the estimated positions of the remaining legislators are substantively unchanged across thresholds, indicating that the main results are not driven by the inclusion of highly absent legislators (see SM2).

Although the roll-call data are drawn from Fábrega (2025), we do not use the dynamic ideal-point estimates reported there. Those estimates, while suitable for tracing individual trajectories, are obtained without longitudinal anchors and therefore do not place legislators on a common ideological scale across periods. To enable comparisons relative to a stable reference point over time, we re-estimate the model using an anchored specification. The resulting estimates are highly correlated with the unanchored ones, but the anchored approach is required for the longitudinal comparisons central to the analysis. Anchors were selected to span the ideological spectrum and to ensure long legislative presence across periods, high roll-call participation, and clearly identifiable ideological positions. The selected anchors are Gastón von Mühlenbrock (right), José Miguel Ortiz (center), and Fidel Espinoza (left). Each appears in five of the six legislative periods and exhibits participation rates above 70 percent. Robustness checks using alternative anchor sets yield nearly identical estimates (see SM3). Moreover, to reflect estimation uncertainty, we report uncertainty intervals for ideal points and propagate this uncertainty to polarization measures by computing period-level quantities over the corresponding uncertainty distributions (see SM4).

While formal polarization indices such as Esteban–Ray (Esteban and Ray 1994) originate in the study of income distributions and mass preferences, the present approach follows standard practice in the analysis of legislative polarization, where polarization dynamics are tracked through the extremity and dispersion of legislators’ ideal points over time Cormack (2016). Using the estimated ideological positions, polarization is operationalized through two complementary measures. The primary indicator is the average absolute ideological distance from a fixed, common reference point over the entire period (*abs*), computed as the mean of absolute ideal points in each legislature. The reference point is fixed by the longitudinal anchoring scheme and is therefore time-invariant by construction. As a robustness check, we also compute a quadratic measure of polarization (the mean of squared ideological positions, *sq*) which places greater weight on extreme observations and assesses sensitivity to highly extreme legislators (see Appendix A).

Finally, because polarization dynamics may be asymmetric, the analysis also examines ideological asymmetry across periods. For this purpose, we report the period-specific mean ideological position and the proportion of legislators located on each side of the ideological axis. These quantities are not used as measures of polarization per se, but as descriptive indicators of balance around the reference point (see appendix B).

Mechanisms of Polarization: Replacement versus Within-Legislator Change

We first establish the measurement strategy and show that procedural conditions remain stable across periods. The empirical analysis then distinguishes three quantities that bear differently on the proposed mechanisms: aggregate change in ideological extremity, the contemporaneous entrant–incumbent gap, and within-legislator change since entry. Models 1–5 examine the first two quantities. Model 6 evaluates the third, and thus adaptation directly, by measuring

each legislator’s change since entry in absolute distance from the contemporaneous median of incumbents, with newcomers excluded from that benchmark.

Model 1 estimates a linear legislative-period trend (*period_num*), the entrant indicator (*groups_t*), and their interaction. Model 2 adds party and individual covariates. Model 3 replaces the linear trend with period fixed effects while retaining the entrant indicator and controls. Model 4 preserves Model 2’s level specification but clusters standard errors by legislator. Model 5 evaluates whether the aggregate temporal pattern changes after the electoral reform and whether any level or slope change differs by entry status.

Model 6 (within-legislator extremity change since entry). For each legislator-period, this specification measures absolute distance from the contemporaneous incumbent median and subtracts that legislator’s entry-period distance from the corresponding entry-period incumbent median. It then estimates a no-intercept linear slope on *tau*, the number of calendar legislative periods elapsed since entry (0–5), with HC1 standard errors clustered by legislator. Thus, a positive coefficient denotes increasing relative extremity, not movement toward the positive/right side of the ideological scale. Mean-based, full-chamber, outward-direction, and nonparametric *tau* profiles are retained as robustness analyses. Exact decomposition components, cohort profiles, alternative Model 6 benchmarks, and quadratic-measure results are reported in the supplemental materials.

Additional controls account for individual and contextual factors that may condition revealed positioning. These include sex and age, the number of parties a legislator has belonged to (*quant_parties*) as a proxy for stability versus fluidity in partisan trajectories and the ideological orientation of the executive (*gov_right*), capturing government–opposition dynamics that plausibly shape voting behavior.

We add an exact replacement-only counterfactual using the same anchored legislator-period panel. For legislator *i*, let b_i be his or her first period and define entry extremity as $e_i = |x_{i,b_i}|$. For each observed chamber composition in period *t*, replacement-only polarization is $R_t = N_t^{-1} \sum_{i \in C_t} e_i$: every legislator is held fixed at entry extremity while the actual membership of the chamber, C_t , changes. Observed polarization then satisfies the accounting identity $P_t = R_t + N_t^{-1} \sum_{i \in C_t} (|x_{it}| - e_i)$. This is a descriptive counterfactual, not a causal estimate of the effect of replacement. Given that the observation window begins in 2002–06, first observation is potentially left-censored for legislators already serving in that term.

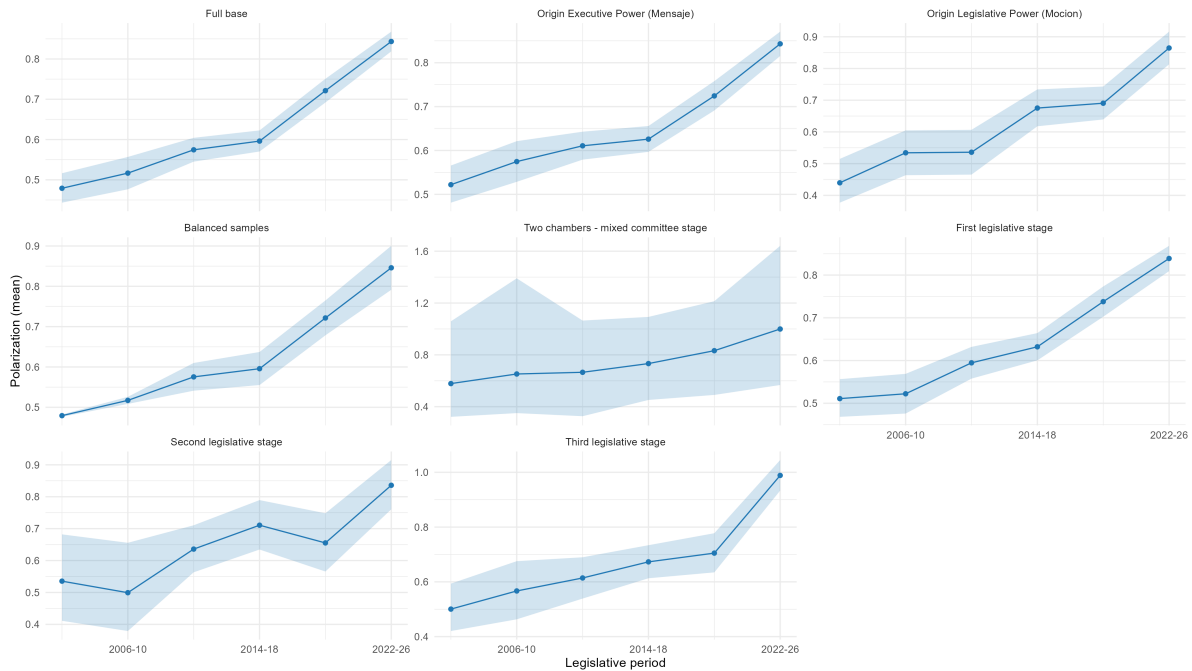
One limitation of the design is that it does not condition explicitly on policy content. Shifts in the thematic agenda could, in principle, affect recovered ideal points even under unchanged procedural rules, and we cannot adjudicate that channel directly here (Moskowitz, Rogowski, and Snyder 2024). At the same time, the analysis spans six legislatures - nearly twenty-four years - and the long-run increase in polarization is observed under broadly stable procedural conditions and across multiple subsets of roll-call activity. These results reduce concerns that the aggregate trend is driven solely by changes in bill origin, legislative stage, or the volume of recorded votes. They do not, however, rule out changes in the substantive composition of the legislative agenda as a contributing source of longitudinal variation in recovered ideal points.

We therefore treat agenda composition as a potentially complementary mechanism that lies outside the scope of the present design, and interpret the main results as evidence on long-run changes in revealed roll-call polarization rather than as evidence that agenda change plays no role.

Results

The resulting trajectory of polarization, measured as the average absolute distance from a fixed reference point (*abs*), is smooth and monotonic, increasing from 0.479 in 2002–06 to 0.843 in 2022–26, an increase of approximately 76%. This pattern points to an accumulative process rather than episodic polarization driven by isolated political events. Importantly, it is not confined to the aggregate sample. The same upward trajectory is observed when the analysis is replicated across substantively relevant subsets of votes, including bills of executive and legislative origin, as well as across different stages of the lawmaking process. This pattern is also robust to excluding legislators with high abstention or absence rates. Together, these results suggest that rising ideological polarization reflects a broad and persistent dynamic of legislative behavior rather than changes confined to specific types of bills or procedural stages.

Figure 1 - Dynamic Ideological Polarization in the Chilean Chamber of Deputies (2002–2026)



When polarization is measured as the mean of squared ideological positions (sq), the resulting trajectories closely mirror those obtained using a fixed ideological reference point. Between 2002–06 and 2022–26, this measure increases by approximately 154%, compared with 76% for the primary absolute-distance measure. The larger increase under the quadratic specification indicates that the polarization trend also involves an increasing contribution of legislators located farther in the ideological tails. This pattern is also visible in the upper tail of the distribution: relative to 2002–06, ideological extremity at the 90th percentile increases by about 50%, while the 95th percentile increases by 71% by 2022–26 (see SM5).

An additional question is whether the observed increase in polarization is systematically asymmetric, reflecting greater ideological movement on one side of the spectrum. The evidence provides little support for this interpretation. Skewness remains close to zero in all periods even when left/right shares tilt in some periods, indicating that the ideological distribution is broadly symmetric despite its increasing dispersion (see Appendix B, Table 3). Therefore, these results suggest that rising polarization reflects a widening of the ideological space on both sides of the reference point rather than a unidirectional radicalization driven by a single ideology.

Models 1–5 capture the aggregate temporal rise and the entrant–incumbent gap. The positive period association is stable across specifications and samples, including 100 balanced vote samples with 1,950 roll-calls per period, and it persists with party and individual controls. Model 3’s period fixed effects likewise rise relative to 2002–06.

Across the main specifications, newly elected legislators are located approximately 0.10 ideal-point units farther from the anchored reference point than incumbents. Model 5 finds no systematic post-reform level or slope discontinuity in the full sample. The full-sample slope in Model 6 is approximately -0.003 distance units per elapsed legislative period and is statistically indistinguishable from zero. Thus, adaptation shows no systematic trend toward greater extremity. Although positive coefficients appear in two vote subsamples, they do not form a consistent pattern across bill origins or legislative stages, and the full-sample and benchmark-robustness estimates remain statistically indistinguishable from zero.

Successive first-observed cohorts display increasingly extreme mean positions at first observation: 0.479, 0.537, 0.641, 0.713, 0.759, and 0.900 across the six periods. Observed polarization rises from 0.4790 in 2002–06 to 0.8435 in 2022–26, an increase of 0.3644, or approximately 76.1%. Holding every legislator’s extremity fixed at its first observed value while retaining the chamber’s actual membership in each period yields 0.8454 in 2022–26, an increase of 0.3663. The descriptive accounting ratio is 1.0052 (100.5%), and the final aggregate within-legislator deviation is -0.0019. Thus, the replacement-only counterfactual reproduces essentially the entire observed increase in polarization, while the aggregate within-legislator component is approximately zero and slightly negative.

Of the two mechanisms directly contrasted here, replacement receives empirical support, whereas systematic adaptation does not. Exact components and the quadratic result—an observed increase of 0.5457, a replacement-only increase of 0.5504, an accounting ratio of

100.85%, and a within component of -0.0047—are reported in the supplemental materials (see figure 2).

Figure 2 - Observed polarization and replacement-only counterfactual

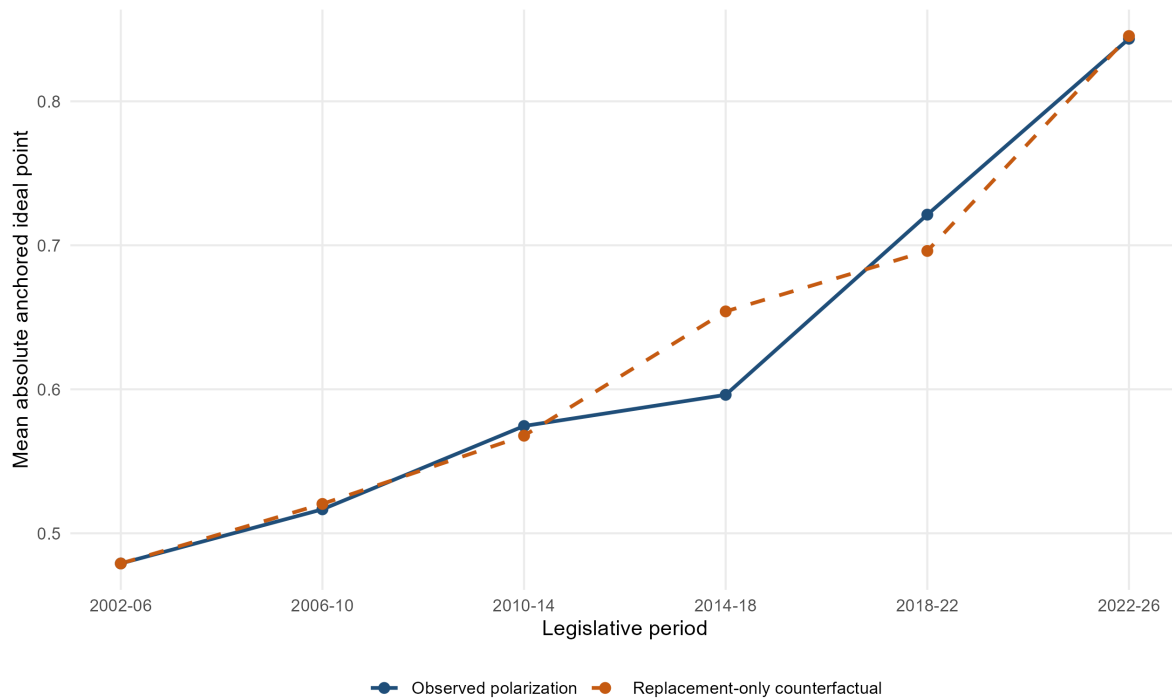


Table 2: Key coefficients: Models 1-5 use absolute ideology; Model 6 uses change in distance to the incumbent median

Sample	Term	M1	M2	M3 (FE)	M4 (Clust)	M5 (Reform)	M6 (Extremity change)
Full sample (integrated)	Elite replacement (new entrant)	0.109*** (0.028)	0.103*** (0.029)	0.107*** (0.032)	0.103*** (0.028)	0.153* (0.072)	
Full sample (integrated)	Legislative period trend	0.065*** (0.014)	0.067*** (0.009)		0.067*** (0.007)	0.008 (0.021)	
Full sample (integrated)	Replacement x period (new entrant)	0.015 (0.017)				0.055 (0.030)	
Full sample (integrated)	Post-reform level shift					-0.019 (0.114)	
Full sample (integrated)	Post-reform slope change					0.107 (0.073)	
Full sample (integrated)	Post-reform x replacement (level)					-0.137 (0.179)	
Full sample (integrated)	Post-reform x replacement (slope)					0.016 (0.102)	
Full sample (integrated)	Within-legislator extremity change (incumbent median)						-0.003 (0.016)
Full sample (integrated)	Period FE: 2006-10			0.104* (0.052)			
Full sample (integrated)	Period FE: 2010-14			0.159** (0.052)			
Full sample (integrated)	Period FE: 2014-18			0.159** (0.052)			
Full sample (integrated)	Period FE: 2018-22			0.257*** (0.049)			
Full sample (integrated)	Period FE: 2022-26			0.380*** (0.053)			
Balanced subsample (mean 100 runs)	Elite replacement (new entrant)	0.268*** (0.068)	0.253*** (0.070)	0.263*** (0.077)	0.253*** (0.067)	0.374* (0.175)	
Balanced subsample (mean 100 runs)	Legislative period trend	0.160*** (0.035)	0.164*** (0.022)		0.164*** (0.018)	0.019 (0.051)	
Balanced subsample (mean 100 runs)	Replacement x period (new entrant)	0.037 (0.042)				0.135 (0.073)	
Balanced subsample (mean 100 runs)	Post-reform level shift					-0.052 (0.279)	
Balanced subsample (mean 100 runs)	Post-reform slope change					0.268 (0.177)	
Balanced subsample (mean 100 runs)	Post-reform x replacement (level)					-0.336 (0.436)	
Balanced subsample (mean 100 runs)	Post-reform x replacement (slope)					0.042 (0.248)	
Balanced subsample (mean 100 runs)	Within-legislator extremity change (incumbent median)						-0.003 (0.016)
Bill origin: Mensaje	Elite replacement (new entrant)	0.254*** (0.069)	0.240*** (0.072)	0.270*** (0.079)	0.240*** (0.069)	0.441* (0.174)	
Bill origin: Mensaje	Legislative period trend	0.124*** (0.036)	0.138*** (0.022)		0.138*** (0.018)	-0.026 (0.052)	
Bill origin: Mensaje	Replacement x period (new entrant)	0.047 (0.043)				0.185* (0.074)	
Bill origin: Mensaje	Post-reform level shift					-0.029 (0.288)	
Bill origin: Mensaje	Post-reform slope change					0.275 (0.184)	
Bill origin: Mensaje	Post-reform x replacement (level)					-0.442 (0.443)	
Bill origin: Mensaje	Post-reform x replacement (slope)					0.012 (0.255)	
Bill origin: Mensaje	Within-legislator extremity change (incumbent median)						-0.021 (0.016)
Bill origin: Mocion	Elite replacement (new entrant)	0.193** (0.068)	0.114* (0.057)	0.159* (0.063)	0.114* (0.056)	0.274* (0.135)	
Bill origin: Mocion	Legislative period trend	0.167*** (0.035)	0.145*** (0.018)		0.145*** (0.018)	0.105* (0.041)	
Bill origin: Mocion	Replacement x period (new entrant)	0.030 (0.042)				0.100 (0.054)	
Bill origin: Mocion	Post-reform level shift					0.154 (0.261)	
Bill origin: Mocion	Post-reform slope change					-0.063 (0.179)	
Bill origin: Mocion	Post-reform x replacement (level)					-0.551 (0.333)	
Bill origin: Mocion	Post-reform x replacement (slope)					0.175 (0.203)	
Bill origin: Mocion	Within-legislator extremity change (incumbent median)						0.102*** (0.017)
Vote step: Primer tramite	Elite replacement (new entrant)	0.269*** (0.068)	0.263*** (0.071)	0.269*** (0.078)	0.263*** (0.067)	0.355* (0.168)	
Vote step: Primer tramite	Legislative period trend	0.150*** (0.035)	0.154*** (0.022)		0.154*** (0.018)	0.052 (0.050)	

Table 2: Key coefficients: Models 1-5 use absolute ideology; Model 6 uses change in distance to the incumbent median
(continued)

Sample	Term	M1	M2	M3 (FE)	M4 (Clust)	M5 (Reform)	M6 (Extremity change)
Vote step: Primer tramite	Replacement x period (new entrant)	0.034 (0.042)				0.102 (0.071)	
Vote step: Primer tramite	Post-reform level shift					0.000 (0.284)	
Vote step: Primer tramite	Post-reform slope change					0.149 (0.179)	
Vote step: Primer tramite	Post-reform x replacement (level)					-0.383 (0.438)	
Vote step: Primer tramite	Post-reform x replacement (slope)					0.130 (0.251)	
Vote step: Primer tramite	Within-legislator extremity change (incumbent median)						-0.005 (0.017)
Vote step: Segundo tramite	Elite replacement (new entrant)	0.230** (0.070)	0.241** (0.074)	0.275*** (0.080)	0.241*** (0.072)	0.257 (0.160)	
Vote step: Segundo tramite	Legislative period trend	0.128*** (0.036)	0.139*** (0.023)		0.139*** (0.020)	0.197*** (0.057)	
Vote step: Segundo tramite	Replacement x period (new entrant)	0.017 (0.043)				-0.020 (0.072)	
Vote step: Segundo tramite	Post-reform level shift					-0.602 (0.307)	
Vote step: Segundo tramite	Post-reform slope change					0.192 (0.189)	
Vote step: Segundo tramite	Post-reform x replacement (level)					-0.295 (0.432)	
Vote step: Segundo tramite	Post-reform x replacement (slope)					0.259 (0.258)	
Vote step: Segundo tramite	Within-legislator extremity change (incumbent median)						-0.003 (0.024)
Vote step: Tercer tramite	Elite replacement (new entrant)	0.239*** (0.067)	0.172* (0.069)	0.211** (0.075)	0.172* (0.072)	0.406* (0.179)	
Vote step: Tercer tramite	Legislative period trend	0.184*** (0.035)	0.164*** (0.021)		0.164*** (0.020)	0.054 (0.068)	
Vote step: Tercer tramite	Replacement x period (new entrant)	0.020 (0.042)				0.149 (0.091)	
Vote step: Tercer tramite	Post-reform level shift					-0.424 (0.255)	
Vote step: Tercer tramite	Post-reform slope change					0.449* (0.196)	
Vote step: Tercer tramite	Post-reform x replacement (level)					-0.327 (0.398)	
Vote step: Tercer tramite	Post-reform x replacement (slope)					-0.093 (0.254)	
Vote step: Tercer tramite	Within-legislator extremity change (incumbent median)						-0.009 (0.025)
Vote step: Comision mixta	Elite replacement (new entrant)	0.101 (0.069)	-0.017 (0.065)	-0.021 (0.072)	-0.017 (0.061)	0.264 (0.139)	
Vote step: Comision mixta	Legislative period trend	0.141*** (0.036)	0.086*** (0.020)		0.086*** (0.023)	-0.040 (0.058)	
Vote step: Comision mixta	Replacement x period (new entrant)	0.018 (0.043)				0.176** (0.065)	
Vote step: Comision mixta	Post-reform level shift					0.194 (0.265)	
Vote step: Comision mixta	Post-reform slope change					0.158 (0.181)	
Vote step: Comision mixta	Post-reform x replacement (level)					-0.173 (0.349)	
Vote step: Comision mixta	Post-reform x replacement (slope)					-0.315 (0.218)	
Vote step: Comision mixta	Within-legislator extremity change (incumbent median)						0.073* (0.029)

In sum, ideological polarization in the Chilean Chamber of Deputies increased steadily between 2002 and 2026, but the evidence points strongly toward compositional replacement rather than systematic within-legislator adaptation. Later cohorts are observed at increasingly extreme positions when they first appear in the data, and holding legislators fixed at their entry extremity reproduces essentially the entire aggregate increase. Legislators who remain in office, by contrast, show no systematic tendency to become more extreme relative to the incumbent center.

Discussion

The central finding is a marked increase in ideological polarization in the Chilean Chamber of Deputies over the past two decades, driven primarily by changes in who enters and leaves the legislature. The chamber becomes progressively more polarized as successive cohorts arrive at more extreme positions, while legislators who remain in office show little evidence of systematic ideological movement over their legislative careers. The replacement-only counterfactual reinforces this interpretation by reproducing almost the entire aggregate increase while holding legislators fixed at their entry extremity.

The Chilean case is analytically informative because it combines rising elite polarization with sustained electoral dealignment and declining partisan identification at the mass level. Under these conditions, the observed increase in parliamentary polarization is reproduced almost entirely by cumulative replacement: successive cohorts enter at increasingly extreme positions, while legislators who remain in office show no systematic tendency to become more extreme after entry. The analysis does not identify why these successive cohorts enter at more extreme positions, leaving open the role of electoral demand, candidate selection, party recruitment, and other processes operating before or at entry.

This pattern changes how the aggregate trend should be interpreted. A legislature can become substantially more polarized even when individual legislators exhibit little systematic movement after entering office. In the Chilean case, the long-run transformation of the chamber therefore appears to operate mainly through the accumulation of cohort differences rather than through a common process of ideological adaptation among incumbents. The distinction is important because the same aggregate trajectory can arise from different underlying processes, with correspondingly different implications for theories of polarization.

The evidence also narrows the range of mechanisms that can plausibly account for the observed increase. Candidate selection, party recruitment, electoral incentives, and changes in the pool of politically viable candidates remain plausible explanations for why entering cohorts become progressively more extreme. The present design cannot distinguish among these processes. Institutional and procedural features that shape strategic interaction within the chamber, including agenda control, coordination mechanisms, and rule-based incentives, may also matter for legislative behavior, but the within-legislator estimates provide little support for a general

process in which continued exposure to the institution systematically moves legislators toward greater extremity.

A related limitation concerns issue composition. While the analysis shows that polarization trends are stable across bill origin and legislative stage, it does not condition explicitly on policy content. Shifts in the thematic agenda could, in principle, affect recovered ideal points even under unchanged procedural rules. Addressing this concern would require issue-constant designs or text-based classification strategies, such as restricting analysis to stable policy domains or tracking agenda content over time (Moskowitz, Rogowski, and Snyder 2024). We therefore leave this as an avenue for future research.

From a comparative perspective, these findings underscore the value of longitudinal behavioral data for distinguishing compositional change from within-legislator movement. The Chilean case shows that sustained elite polarization can accumulate within a multiparty legislature through changes in parliamentary composition even under conditions of electoral dealignment and weak partisan attachment at the mass level. Whether this pattern extends to other parliamentary systems remains an open empirical question. Comparative work that traces entry cohorts and within-legislator trajectories across countries would help establish when polarization is driven primarily by electoral replacement and when institutional experience contributes more directly to ideological change.

Appendix

A. Measures of ideological polarization

Let $x_{i,t} \in \mathbb{R}$ denote the dynamically estimated ideological position of legislator $i = 1, \dots, N_t$ in legislative period $t = 1, \dots, T$, with $T = 6$. Because the dynamic estimation places all legislators on a common longitudinal scale, the origin 0 provides a fixed reference point across legislative periods. Our primary measure of individual ideological extremity is:

$$E_{i,t} = |x_{i,t}|.$$

Period-level polarization is therefore:

$$Pol_t^{abs} = \frac{1}{N_t} \sum_{i=1}^{N_t} |x_{i,t}|.$$

As a robustness measure that assigns greater weight to extreme positions, we also compute

$$Pol_t^{sq} = \frac{1}{N_t} \sum_{i=1}^{N_t} x_{i,t}^2.$$

B. Asymmetry and ideological composition

As a descriptive complement, we report net ideological asymmetry as the period mean: $Asym_t = \bar{x}_t$. We also report the proportion of legislators located on each side of the ideological axis: $share_t^R = \frac{1}{N_t} \sum_{i=1}^{N_t} \mathbf{1}[x_{i,t} > 0]$ and $share_t^L = \frac{1}{N_t} \sum_{i=1}^{N_t} \mathbf{1}[x_{i,t} < 0]$, and the skewness of the distribution. Skewness captures tail asymmetry (i.e., whether the distribution has a longer tail on one side), whereas left/right shares simply describe how many legislators fall on each side of the zero threshold. Table 3 shows that the chamber’s center (mean/median) and the left/right shares shift across periods (sometimes producing clear majorities on one side) yet skewness remains close to zero throughout, indicating limited tail asymmetry even when the left/right split is uneven.

Table 3: Ideology center and distributional asymmetry by legislative period.

Period	Mean ideology	Median ideology	Share left (%)	Share right (%)	Skewness
2002-06	-0.336	-0.130	63.6	36.4	-0.070
2006-10	-0.298	-0.443	56.9	43.1	-0.003
2010-14	0.302	0.208	43.9	56.1	0.105
2014-18	-0.545	-0.714	68.6	31.4	0.024
2018-22	0.232	0.218	42.3	57.7	-0.059
2022-26	-0.280	-0.382	55.4	44.6	0.063

C. Regressions

Models 1–5 estimate aggregate temporal change and the entrant–incumbent gap in legislator-period polarization outcomes. They are complemented by Model 6, which directly evaluates within-legislator change since entry, and by the replacement-only accounting exercise described in the main text.

Let y_{it} denote legislator i ’s ideological polarization in period t (*abs* or *sq*). Let New_{it} be an indicator equal to 1 if legislator i is a new entrant in period t (did not hold a seat in $t - 1$), and 0 otherwise. Let t be a linear period index (in the empirical implementation denoted as *period_num*). Let X_{it} collect the covariates: *party*, *sex*, *age_{it}*, *quant_parties* (number of parties in which a given legislator has been), and *gov_right*, a dummy to identify periods under the rule of a right-wing government. Then:

Model 1 (trend + replacement + interaction):

$$y_{it} = \alpha + \beta_1 New_{it} + \beta_2 t + \beta_3 (New_{it} \times t) + \varepsilon_{it}$$

Model 2 (trend + replacement + controls):

$$y_{it} = \alpha + \beta_1 New_{it} + \beta_2 t + \gamma^\top X_{it} + \varepsilon_{it}$$

Model 3 (period fixed effects; no imposed linear trend):

$$y_{it} = \alpha + \beta_1 \text{New}_{it} + \gamma^\top X_{it} + \sum_{k=2}^T \delta_k \mathbb{1}\{t = k\} + \varepsilon_{it}$$

where $\mathbb{1}(t = k)$ is an indicator for period (k), with period (1) as the omitted reference category.

Model 4 (same specification as Model 2 plus individual clustered standard errors):

$$y_{it} = \alpha + \beta_1 \text{New}_{it} + \beta_2 t + \gamma^\top X_{it} + \varepsilon_{it},$$

estimated by OLS as in Model 2, but with heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors clustered by legislator i (HC1), allowing arbitrary correlation of ε_{it} within legislators over time.

Model 5 (post-reform interruption with heterogeneity by entry status):

$$y_{it} = \alpha + \beta_1 \text{New}_{it} + \beta_2 t + \beta_3 (\text{New}_{it} \times t) + \theta_1 \text{Post}_t + \theta_2 (\text{Post}_t \times t) + \theta_3 (\text{Post}_t \times \text{New}_{it}) + \theta_4 (\text{Post}_t \times \text{New}_{it} \times t) + \gamma^\top X_{it} + \varepsilon_{it}.$$

This model extends the baseline aggregate trend specification by allowing for a post-reform level shift and temporal slope change, both of which may differ between newcomers and incumbents, net of controls.

Model 6 (within-legislator extremity change since entry):

Let $x_{i,t}$ denote legislator i 's ideology in calendar legislative period t , let b_i be the first observed period, and let c_t^{inc} be the median ideology among legislators who entered before t (newcomers are excluded; at least ten incumbents are required). Define $d_{i,t} = |x_{i,t} - c_t^{inc}|$ and $\Delta d_{i,t} = d_{i,t} - d_{i,b_i}$. With $\tau_{i,t} = t - b_i \in \{0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5\}$, the primary specification is $\Delta d_{i,t} = \beta \tau_{i,t} + \varepsilon_{i,t}$, estimated without an intercept and with HC1 standard errors clustered by legislator. Entry observations have $\tau = 0$ and $\Delta d = 0$ by construction; legislators whose entry-period incumbent benchmark is unavailable do not enter this specification.

The main table reports β , the linear average change in relative extremity per additional calendar legislative period since entry. A separate indicator specification, $\Delta d_{i,t} = \sum_k \beta_k \mathbf{1}(\tau_{i,t} = k) + \varepsilon_{i,t}$, provides the nonparametric *tau* robustness profile; it is not collapsed into the main-table coefficient.

The newcomer indicator used in Models 1–5 identifies contemporaneous entry status, whereas the replacement-only counterfactual follows entry cohorts after they become incumbents. The two therefore capture different aspects of parliamentary replacement: current entry differences and their cumulative persistence in the chamber, respectively.

D. Replacement-only counterfactual and accounting decomposition

Let b_i denote legislator i 's first observed legislative period and define entry extremity as

$$e_i = |x_{i,b_i}|.$$

For the observed set of legislators C_t serving in period t , the replacement-only counterfactual is

$$R_t = \frac{1}{N_t} \sum_{i \in C_t} e_i.$$

This quantity holds every legislator fixed at their first-observed level of extremity while allowing the actual composition of the Chamber to change across periods. Observed polarization can then be written exactly as

$$P_t = R_t + \frac{1}{N_t} \sum_{i \in C_t} (|x_{i,t}| - e_i).$$

The first term captures the entry-stock component generated by the changing composition of the Chamber, while the second captures the average within-legislator deviation from entry extremity. Notice that this is an accounting decomposition and a descriptive counterfactual, not a causal decomposition. Also, because legislators already serving in 2002-06 may have entered the Chamber before the beginning of the observation window, their first observation may be left-censored.

As a robustness check, we therefore repeat the exercise using only cohorts whose entry is observed within the study window, beginning with the 2006-10 cohort. The substantive conclusion is unchanged.

An analogous decomposition is computed using $x_{i,t}^2$ in place of $|x_{i,t}|$.

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